



Recreation vs Transportation

A Tale of Two Bike Share Users





Purpose

Chicago's bike share serves 5.5 million annual trips, but not all riders are the same. This analysis examines 12 months of ridership data (Sept 2024 – Aug 2025) to answer the following:

How do members and casual riders actually use this two-wheeled transportation system differently?





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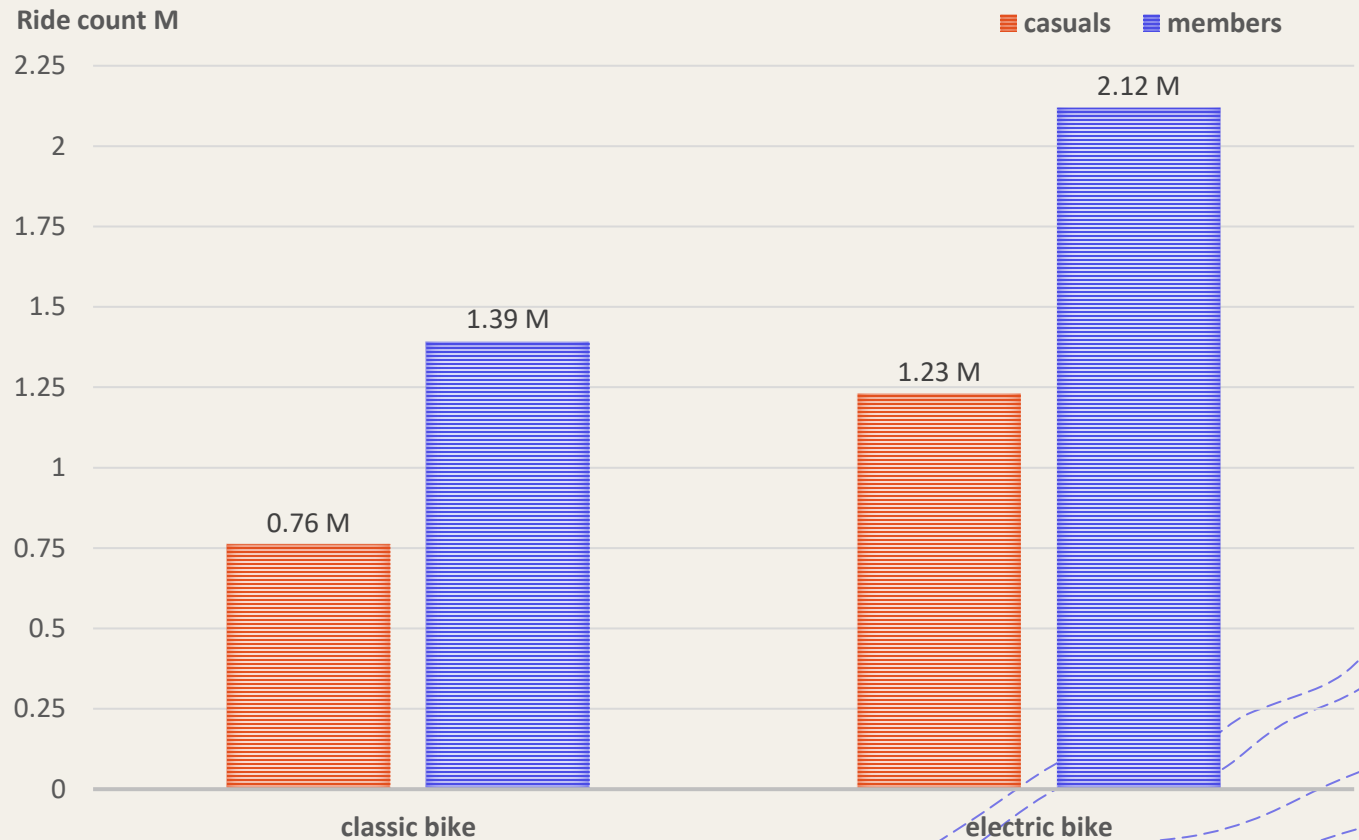




Classic or Electric

- 3.51M members and 1.99M casuals logged bikeshare rides between September 2024 and August 2025
- Despite members taking 1.75x more trips overall, ebike preference is nearly identical (~62%)
- Casuals chose classic bikes 38% of the time while members almost 40% of total rides

Both casuals and members prefer electric bikes





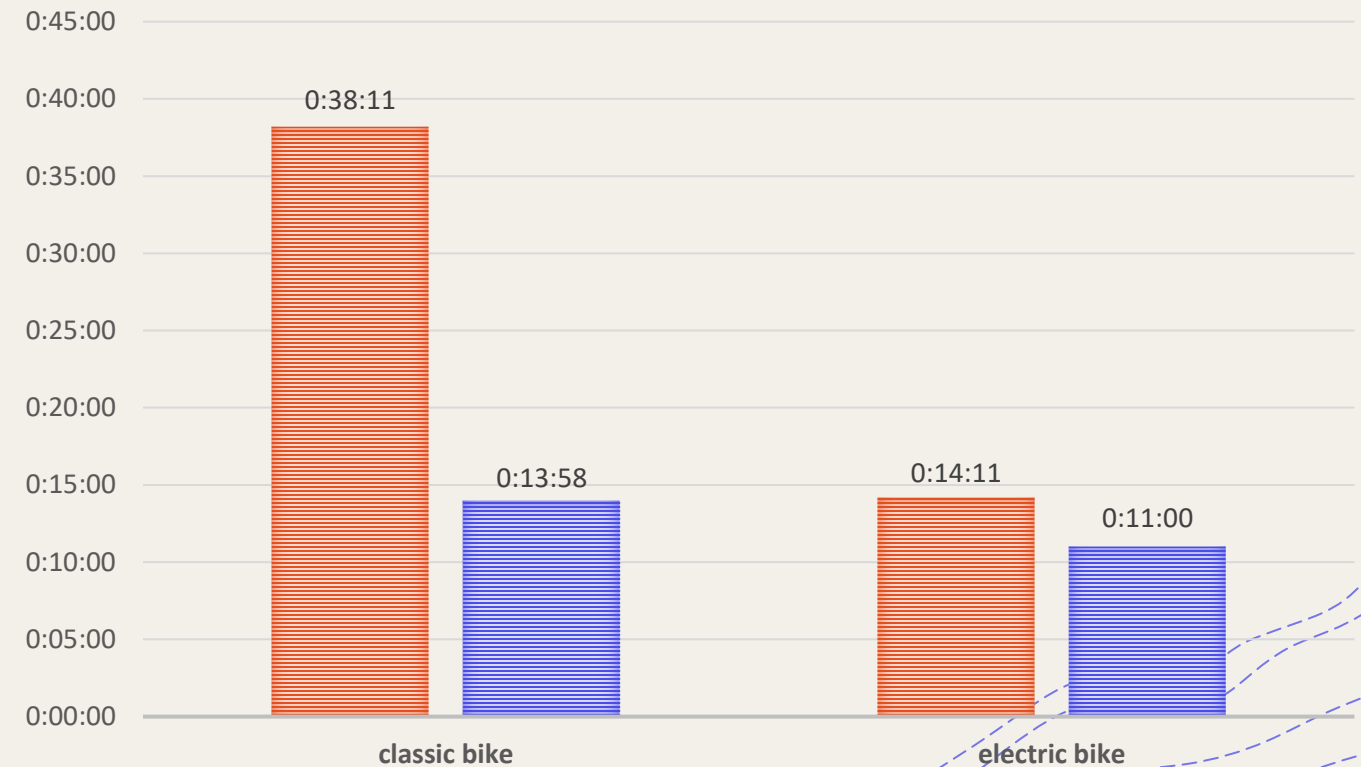
Casuals on Classics

- Casuals add 24 minutes when using classic bikes
- Members add only 3 minutes when using classic bikes
- Members average time on classic and electric saddle are relatively balanced at 11-14 minutes

Casuals ride classic bikes 2.7x longer than members

Avg duration h:m:s

casuals members



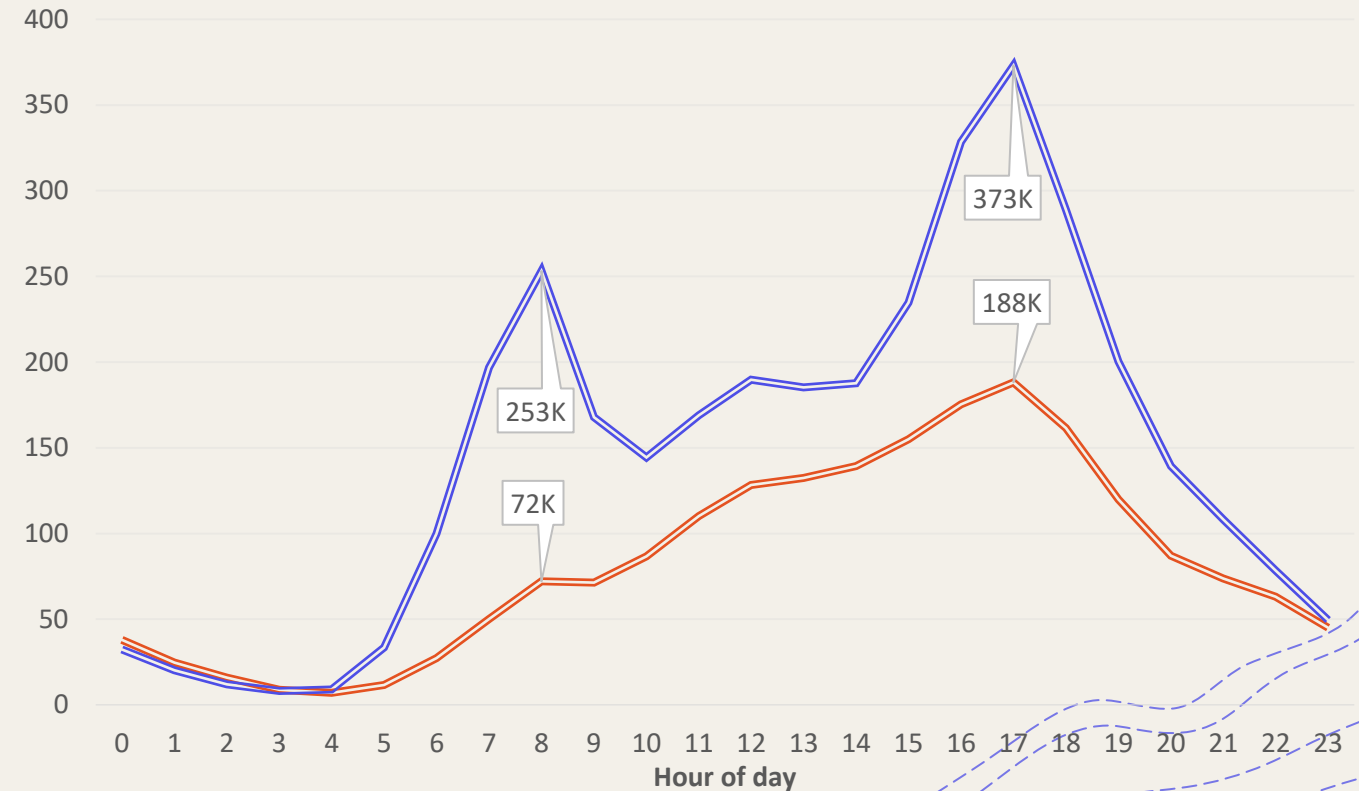


Day in the Bike Share Life

- Members 3.5x more rides than casuals at 8AM
- 5PM: Biggest member volume of the day and 2x more than casuals
- Casuals have a 1.2x (87.1K trips) advantage to members (72.4K trips) between Midnight and 3AM

Members dominate the commuting hours

Ride count K

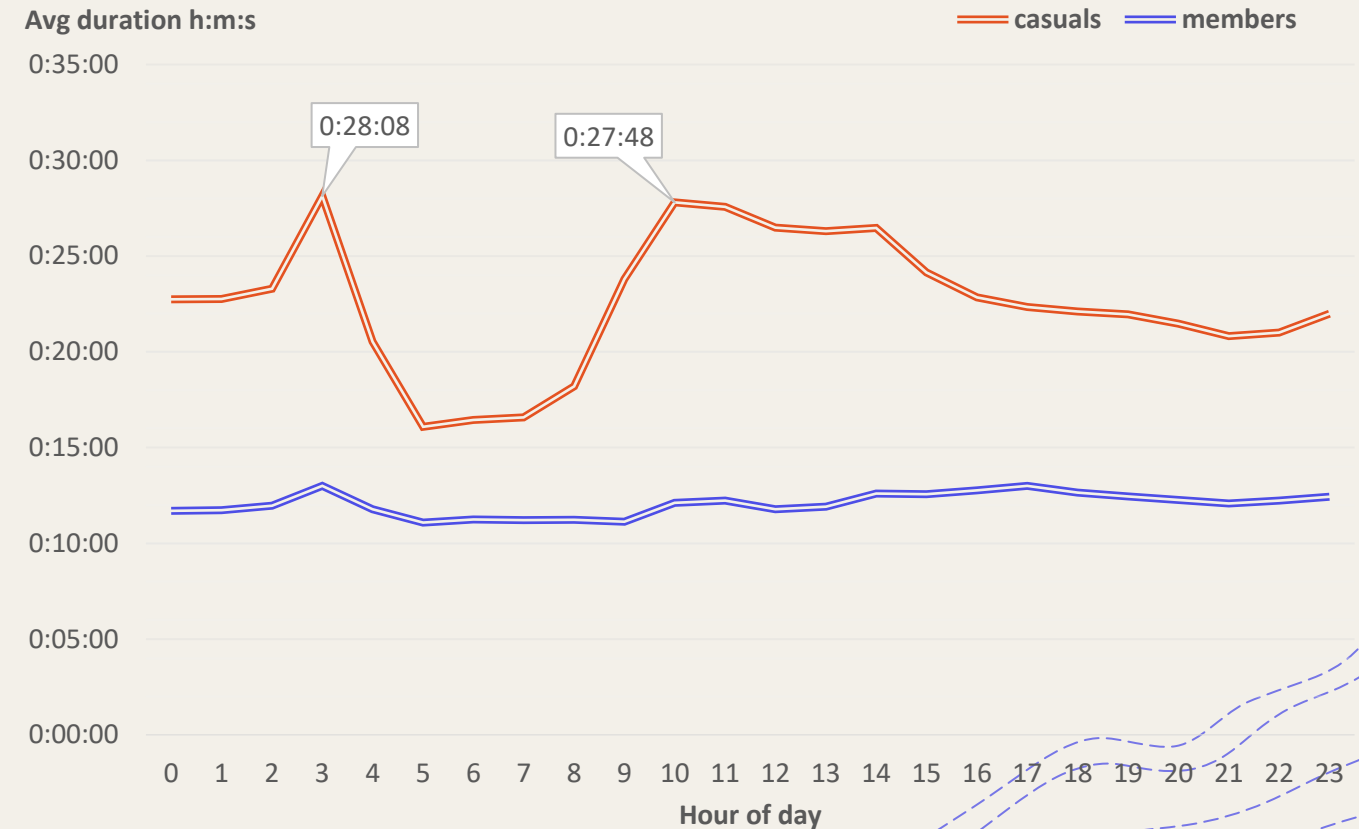




All Day Efficiency vs Exploration

- Members average 11-13 minute rides regardless of hour
- Casuals are more variable averaging 16-28 minute rides
- Casuals ride longest at 3AM and 10AM

Casuals stay in the saddle longer regardless of hour

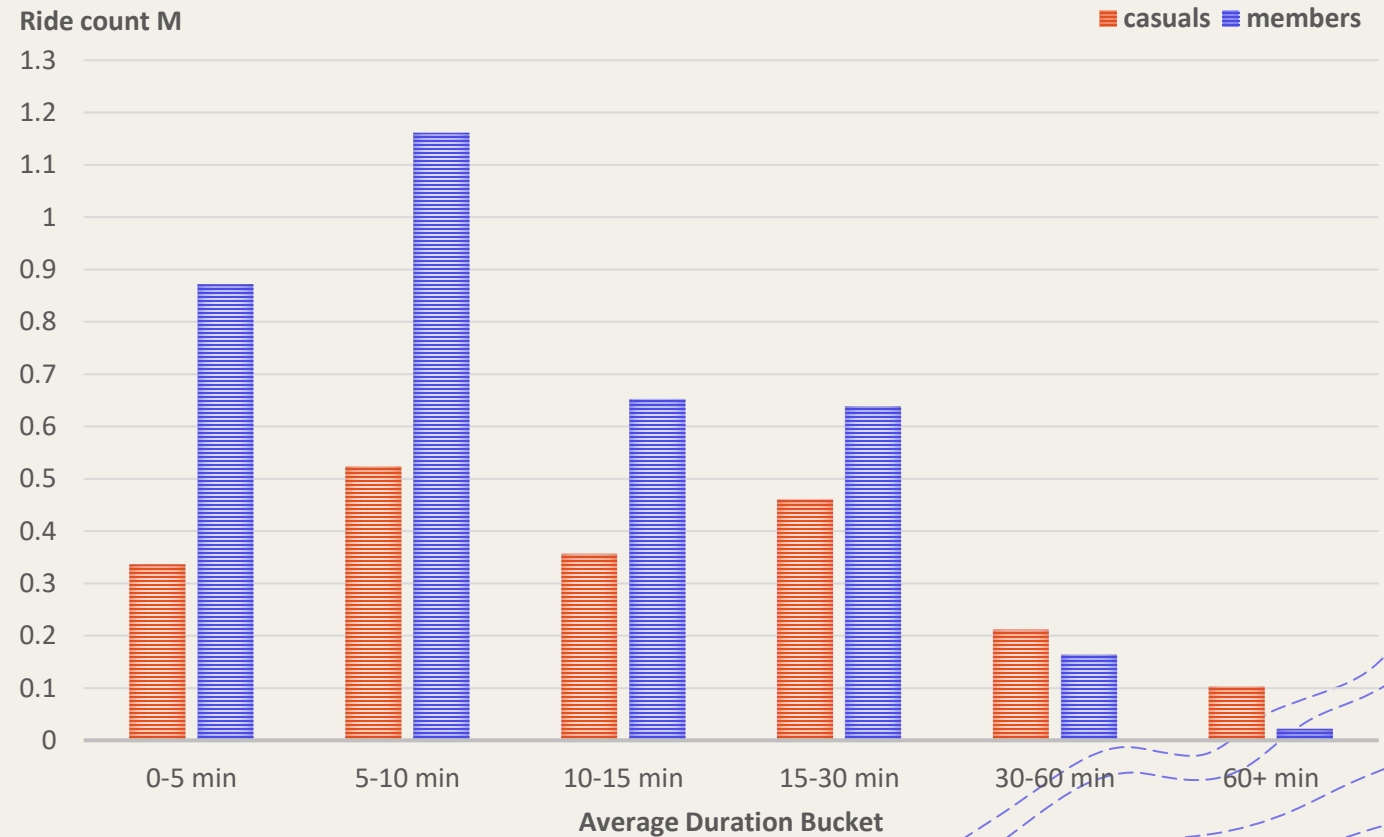




Time Bucket Productivity

- Member quick trips
 - 0-5 min: 2.6x more
 - 5-10 min: 2.2x more
 - 10-15 min: 1.8x more
 - 15-30 min: 1.4x more
- Casuals 4.7x more trips at 60+ minutes

Members lead all volume buckets less than 30 minutes



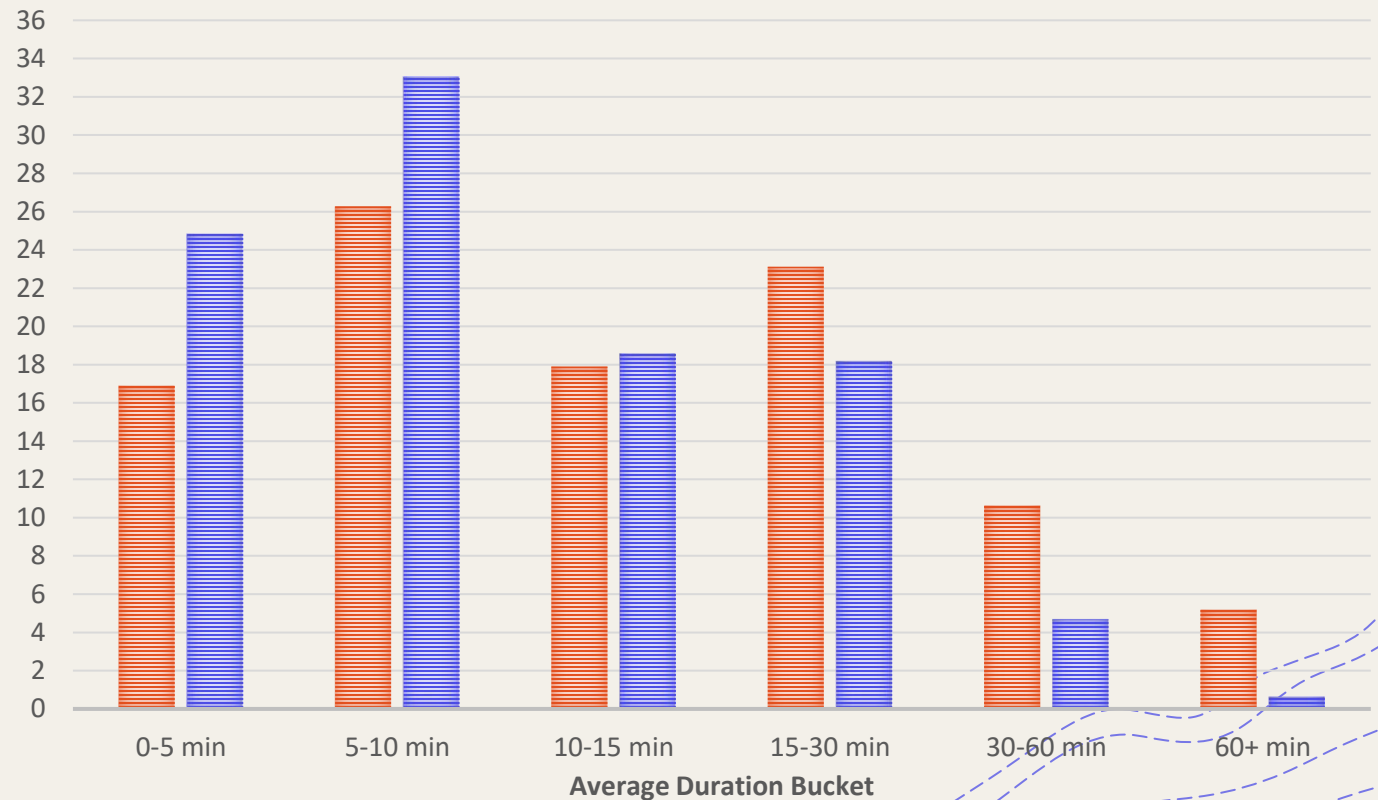


Time Bucket Distribution

- Casuals leading in
 - 15-30 min: 1.3x more
 - 30-60 min: 2.3x more
 - 60+ min: 8.2x more
- 76% of members concentrate below 15 minutes vs 61% of casuals
- 39% of casuals extend rides 15 minutes and above vs 24% of members

Casuals dominate 30+ minutes

Ride count %

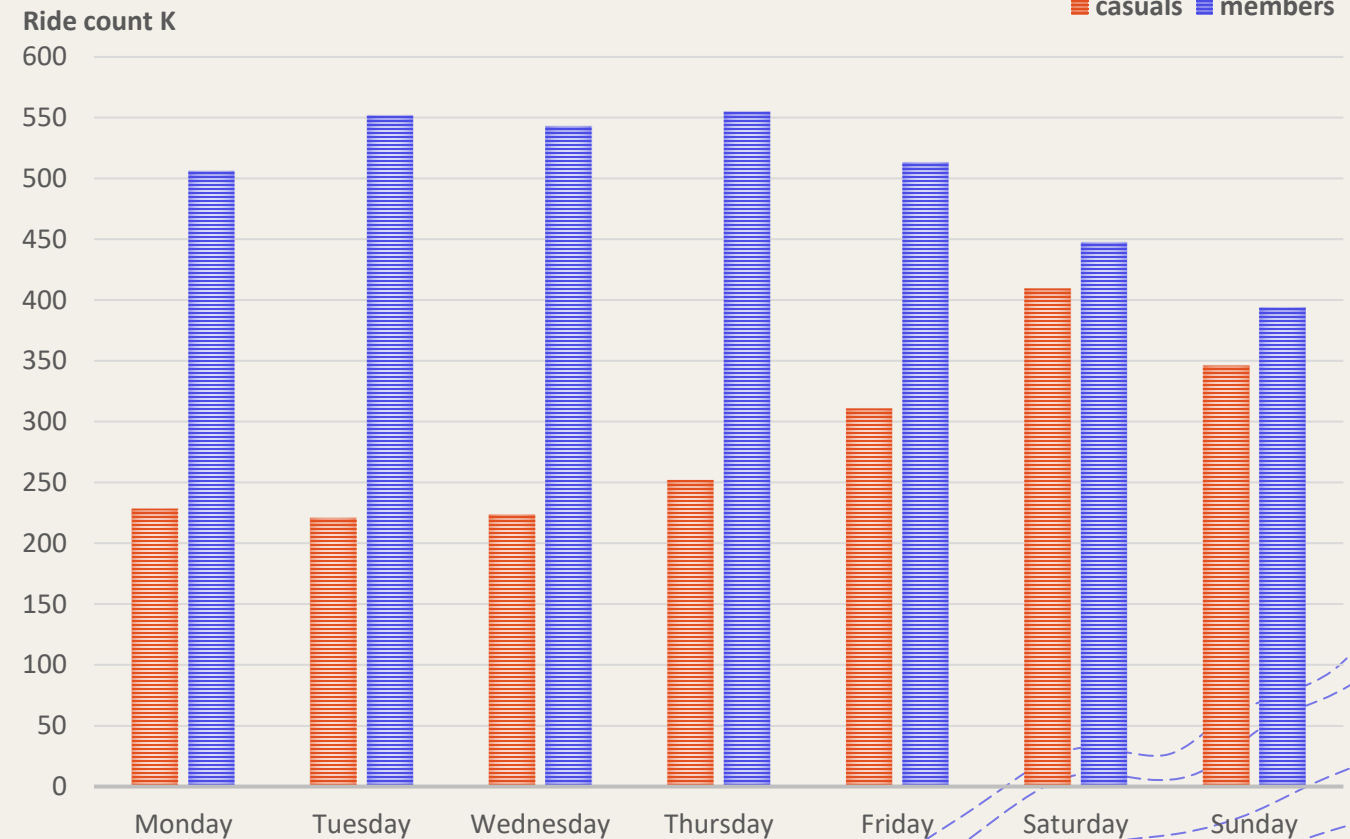




Welcome to the Week

- Member weekday volume 2.2:1 over casuals
- Mon-Thur to Fri change: +34% casuals, -5% members
- Weekday to weekend change: +53% casuals, -21% members
- Weekend near parity with members only 1.1:1 over casuals

Members dominate the weekdays, casuals prefer weekends



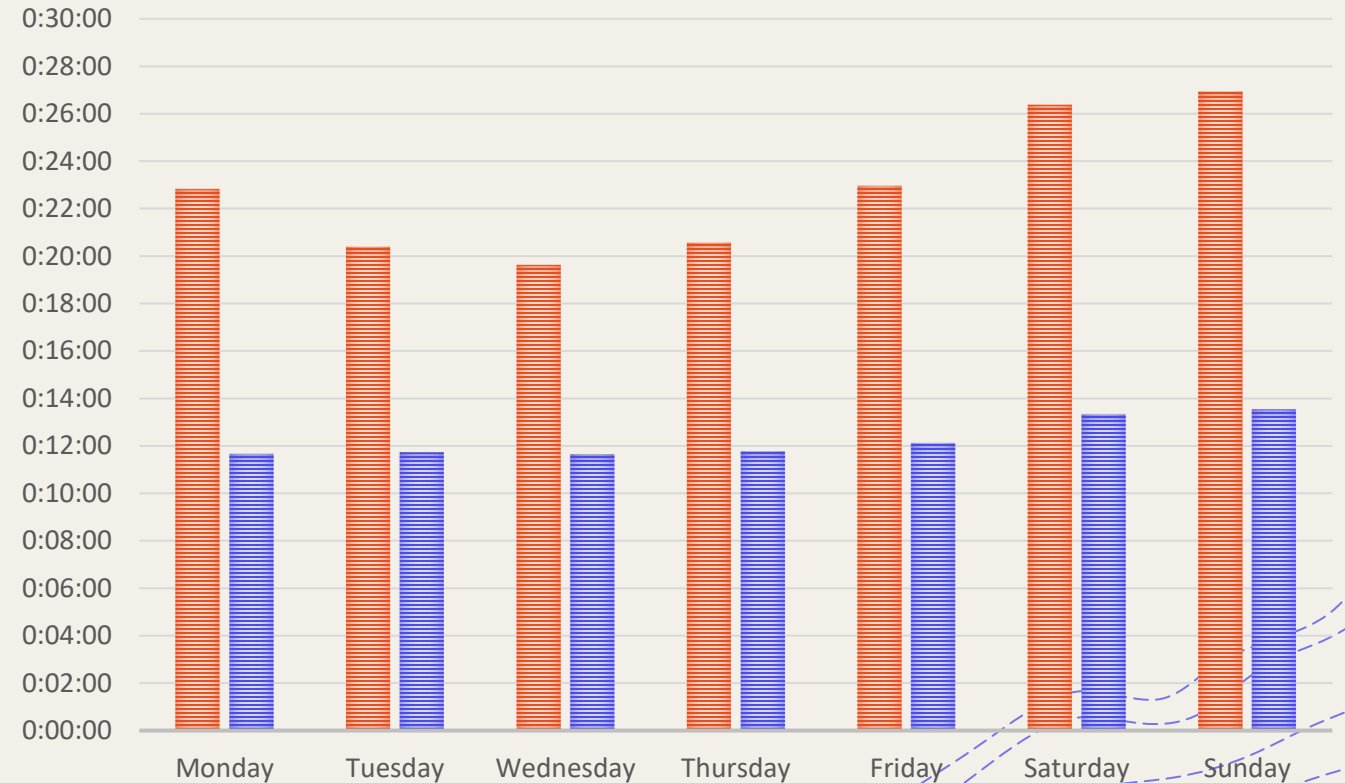


7-day Leisure

- Casuals ride 1.8x longer, but members only differ by 28 seconds (11:39 avg) on weekdays
- Weekday to weekend change: +25% casuals, +14% members
- Sundays are peak duration for both, but casuals still riding almost 2x longer

Casuals ride 1.8x longer on weekdays, 2x on weekends

Avg duration h:m:s

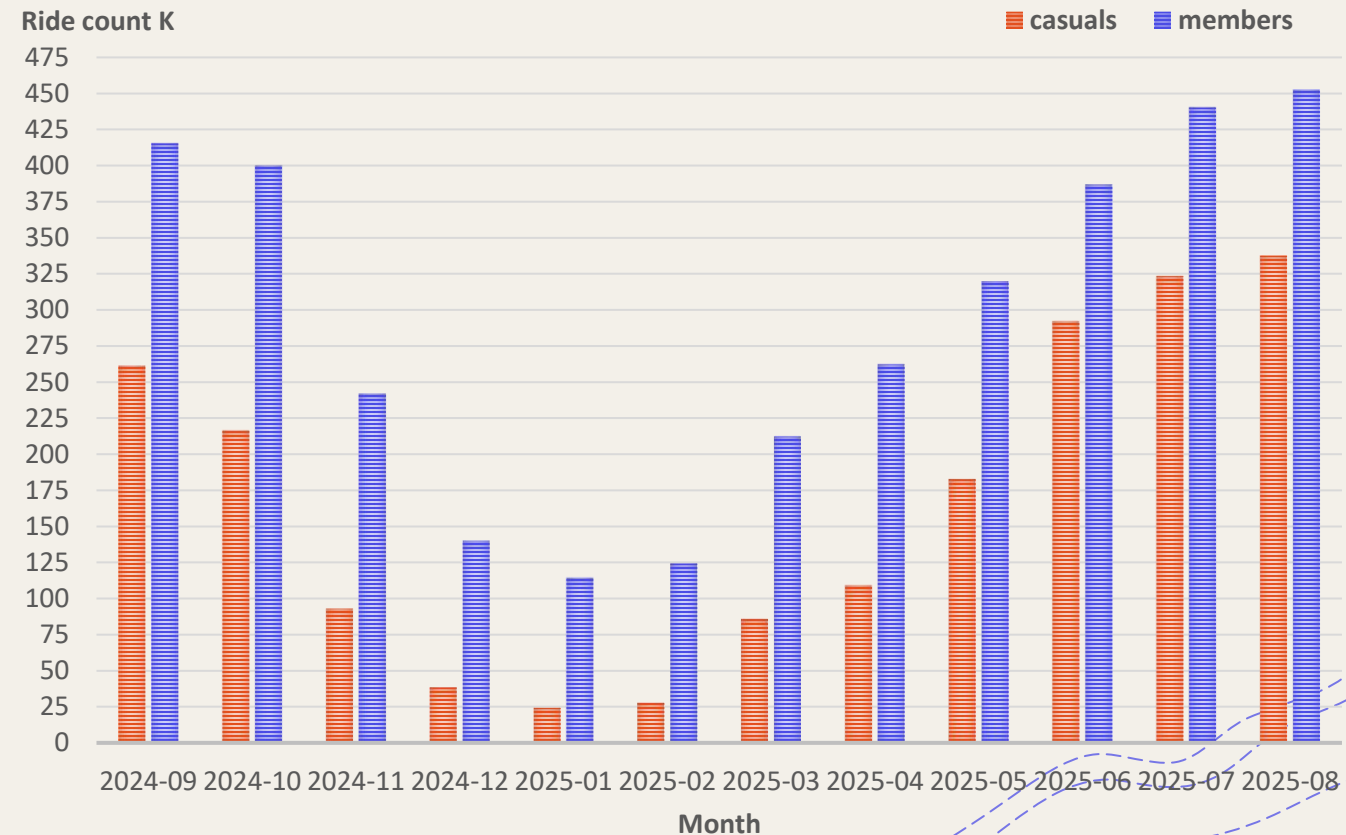




Seasonal Extremes

- January: Members outnumber casuals 4.8:1 by volume, 83% of market share, most in entire year
- Winter to summer growth: 14x for casuals, 4x for members
- Winter: Casuals 4.5%, members 10.8% of total trips
- Summer: Casuals 48%, members 36% of total trips

93% of casuals, 75% of members vanish in winter



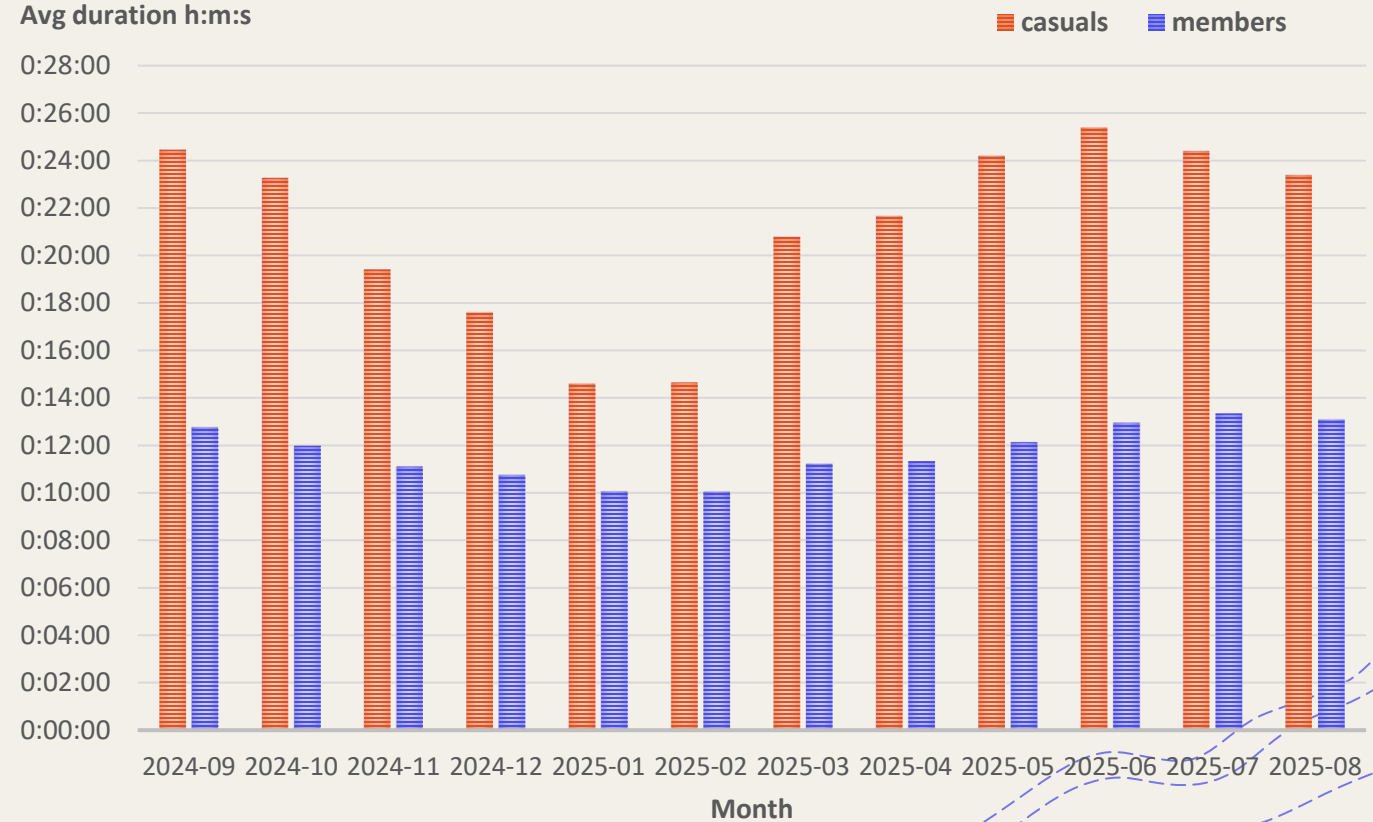


Year in the Saddle

- Casuals average 23+ minutes, members 12 minutes over an entire year
- Members vary by just 3.3 minutes, casuals 10.8 minutes throughout the year
- Winter to summer change:
 - Casuals +56%
 - Members +28%
 - Casuals show 2x more seasonal variation

Casuals dominate ride duration throughout the year

Avg duration h:m:s





Member Conclusion: Essential Transportation

Members use bike share as a vital commuter modality

- Commute-focused – 3.5x advantage at 8 AM and 2x at 5PM, 2.2:1 weekday dominance, 21% weekend drop
- Ridiculously consistent – averages 11-13 min trips across all hours/days, differs only by 28 seconds on weekdays specifically, and trips deviate by only 3.3 minutes on average annually
- Year-round commitment – Leads all ride volumes per month and 1.75x more annually, even in January with the highest market share of 83% and 4.8:1 by volume over casuals





Casuals Conclusion: Seasonal Recreation

Casuals use bike share for leisure, sight-seeing, and exploration

- Relaxed pace – 39% vs just 24% of members extend rides longer than 15 minutes, plus adds 24 minutes per ride vs only 3 minutes for members when on non-electric bikes specifically
- Wild nights/weekends – Has the daily advantage in volume and average ride duration between midnight and 3AM, increases ride durations from 1.8x longer on weekdays to 2x more than members on weekends starting with a +34% Friday surge
- Tourism-related seasonality – 14x winter to summer ride volume growth vs just 4x for members and increase ride durations over the same period by 56% vs members 28%





Key Takeaway

Chicago's bike share doesn't serve just one market; it serves two completely different populations who happen to share the same bikes and transportation infrastructure. Optimizing for one risks alienating the other. A fantastic opportunity lies in the recognition and support of both use cases.





Recommendations: Operational

- Fleet rebalancing by season
 - Reduce winter fleet by 70%, focusing bikes at member commuting corridors.
 - Aggressively expand fleet to tourist zones by April
- Station density optimizations for “last mile”
 - Increase stations within 0.25 miles of commute-related transit hubs for member connections
 - Increase stations within 0.25 miles of major hotel and night-life districts to accommodate casuals





Recommendations: Pricing & Revenue

- Time-based pricing optimization
 - Introduce a 60-90 minute “scenic ride pass” for casuals capturing willingness to pay for recreation and leisure, but keep member pricing focus on trip frequency, not duration
- Seasonal pricing strategy
 - Winter loyalty pricing for members to retain committed users
 - Summer premium day pass pricing for casuals to capture the captive tourist market
- Friday surge pricing for casuals
 - “Weekend starts now” premium Friday afternoon pricing capturing discretionary recreational demand





Recommendations: Marketing & Growth

- Member conversion campaign
 - Aggressive casual-to-member conversion campaigns in March-April to “lock in summer savings now” targeting the non-member, yet committed-local riders
- Classic bike positioning for casuals
 - Add comfort features such as front racks/baskets to classic fleet
 - Market classic bikes to casual riders as “scenic cruisers” for shopping and leisurely lakefront rides





Appendix A: Data Sources and Caveats

- Dataset: 5.5M trips, Sept 2024 – Aug 2025
- Source: Divvy/Chicago bikeshare public data
- Limitations:
 - Analysis represents bikeshare usage only
 - No user-level data (demographics, income, residence)
 - Geographic analysis omitted due to analyst unfamiliarity with Chicago
 - 43 negative duration trips excluded (possible system maintenance Sept 2024)





Appendix B: Analysis Process

- Data Acquisition
 - Downloaded 12 CSV files as months from the following:
 - <https://divvy-tripdata.s3.amazonaws.com/index.html>
- Data Cleaning (MySQL)
 - Created and loaded each file as a new table
 - Created staging copies of each table
 - Tested staging copies for duplicates, blanks, and empty strings
 - Explored field data types and ranges





Appendix B: Analysis Process Continued

- Data Cleaning Continued (MySQL)
 - Combined all staging month tables into a single year table for analysis and established primary key
 - Created, calculated, and populated new ride_length, day_of_week columns
- Exploratory Analysis (MySQL)
 - Aggregated by ride type, hour of the day, duration bucket, day of week, and month
 - Calculated for ride count volume and average ride duration
 - Copied query results to Excel for statistical analysis and visualization





Appendix B: Analysis Process Continued

- Statistical Analysis (Excel)
 - Explored and calculated statistics appropriate to each table
 - Made interpretive notes that may or may not have been included in this presentation
- Visualization (Excel, NOT Tableau)
 - Generated charts initially just for visual reference, but stayed in Excel for visualizations due to the simplicity of charts required and the precise aesthetic control

